BEFORE THE ROOM

A Partner's Workbook for Supporting Homebirth

A GO BOIL THE WATER COMPANION



NOAH JENKS

FREE SAMPLE

A note before you start

This is a free sample of Before the Room, the workbook that goes with Go Boil the Water. You're getting how the workbook works, all of Chapter 1, and Our Birth Rules, one of the pages from the back that you'll lean on in the last few weeks before the birth.

Print it out and grab a pen. Then give Chapter 1 a week.

The His page is just for you, and nobody has to read it. The Together page is for the two of you, so do it on the couch after the kids are asleep or out on a walk. Take the Ask Your Midwife page to your next appointment and ask every question out loud. The This Week box at the bottom is one small thing to do before you turn the page.

You don't need to have read the book to start here, though it helps. Each chapter opens with a short version of what the book says, so you'll know what you're working with.

I wish I'd had something like this before our first birth. I hope it helps you walk into that room ready.

Noah

How to Use This Book

This is your book. It goes alongside Go Boil the Water, one chapter at a time, and it's built for the guy who wants to walk into that room ready instead of guessing.

Every chapter has the same four parts.

His page is for you alone. Nobody has to read it. Write the honest answer, not the one that sounds good.

Together is for the two of you. Sit down with her, ask the questions, and write both of your answers side by side. Listen more than you talk.

Ask your midwife is a page to bring to your next prenatal visit. Ask every question out loud and write down what she says.

This week is one thing to do before you turn the page.

At the back you'll find the pages you'll use in the last few weeks before the birth, and a few more for after. Fill them in as you go. By the time labor starts, most of the thinking will already be done.

You don't have to finish the book before you start this one. If she's thirty-six weeks along and you're just now picking it up, go straight to Chapter 5 and the pages at the back. Then come back for the rest.

CHAPTER 1

Homebirth? That's a Thing?

Go Boil the Water, pages 2 to 8

The short version

When Katie first brought up home birth, I thought it was something from the 1800s, or a documentary, or something people did in a commune wearing tie-dye. I didn't say any of that out loud, which for once was the right instinct.

Here's what I didn't know. Birth happened at home for almost all of human history, and the midwife was the person the whole community leaned on. The move to the hospital came fast, mostly in the first half of the 1900s, driven by real lifesaving advances, a demand for pain relief, and the slow squeezing out of midwives. Fathers got moved out to the waiting room. When we were finally let back in, nobody gave us a job.

Home birth today has nothing to do with that pioneer-movie picture. It means a trained midwife, a safety plan, and a hospital nearby if it's needed. It's choices, not chaos.

"We got access to the room without anyone handing us a script for what to do once we were in it."

WORTH REMEMBERING FROM THIS CHAPTER

CHAPTER 1

His page

Just you. Nobody has to read this.

1 **What was your first thought when she brought up home birth? Not the diplomatic answer. The raw one.**

2 **Before you read this chapter, what did you picture when you heard "home birth"? Be specific. What's in the room? Who's there? What's going wrong?**

3 **Where did that picture come from? A movie, a story you heard, something your parents said, or nowhere in particular?**

4 **What surprised you most in this chapter?**

5 **Finish the sentence: "The thing I'm most afraid to say out loud about this is..."**

You don't have to share this page. But if one of these answers is sitting heavy, it's probably the one worth bringing to her.

CHAPTER 1

Together

Sit down with her for this one. Coffee, a walk, the couch after the kids are asleep. You each answer, and you listen more than you talk.

1 How were each of us born? Where, and who was in the room?

HIM

HER

2 When did home birth first come up for you, and what made it stick?

Her question. Your job is to ask a follow-up, not to respond.

HER ANSWER

YOUR FOLLOW-UP QUESTION

3 What's one thing each of us wants to learn more about before we decide anything?

HIM

HER

4 What did you hear from me in this conversation that you didn't expect?

HIM

HER

CHAPTER 1

Ask your midwife

Bring this page to your next visit, or to the first interview if you're still choosing a midwife.

- [ ] What's your training, and what license or certification do you hold?

- [ ] Walk me through what a home birth with you looks like, from the first call to the day after. Who comes, and what do you bring?

- [ ] If something changes during labor, how do you decide it's time to go to the hospital, and which hospital would we go to?

- [ ] Do you offer water birth? What would we need to have ready?

- [ ] Is there a class you'd recommend we take together, like hypnobirthing?

THIS WEEK

Ask your parents how you were born.

Where it happened, how long it took, and where your dad was. If he was in the waiting room, ask him what that was like.

THE PAGES YOU'LL USE

Our Birth Rules

Agree on these together before the birth: what she wants, what she doesn't, and what happens if things change. In the room, your job is to hold the line on them so she doesn't have to. And remember the rule from Chapter 6: if the plan has to change, you protect her, not the plan.

WHAT SHE WANTS DURING LABOR

WHAT SHE DOESN'T WANT

WHO IS IN THE ROOM

IF SHE ASKS FOR PAIN RELIEF

IF THE MIDWIFE RECOMMENDS GOING TO THE HOSPITAL

WHAT WE SAY TO FAMILY WHILE LABOR IS HAPPENING

OUR SIGNAL IF I'M GETTING TENSE

That's Chapter 1. There are nine more.

The full workbook goes chapter by chapter through Go Boil the Water, from the first time she brings up homebirth to the first two weeks at home with your baby. Every chapter has the same four parts you just worked through.

At the back are the rest of the pages you'll use in the last few weeks:

- When It Gets Hard, her answers in her words
- Who's in the Room and Who's on Call
- If Plans Change: Our Transfer Plan
- The Last Week checklist
- Our Golden Hour

And a few for after the birth, including a letter to your baby and what you'd tell the next guy.

Get the full workbook

Printable PDF or paperback at **goboilthewater.com/workbook**

Haven't read the book yet?

Start with Go Boil the Water: A Partner's Guide to Supporting Homebirth, in paperback and Kindle on Amazon, and as an audiobook. Links at **goboilthewater.com**

Know a midwife or doula?

Send this sample to her. She can share it with every family she works with, so more partners walk into the room ready.